

General. In January, Ambassador Indra Mani Pandey took over as the fourth Secretary General of BIMSTEC, a position he will hold for three years.

BIMSTEC's leadership rotates among member states, and each member state has been given the responsibility to take the lead in a sector. Besides, members have achieved notable progress in areas like trade liberalisation, simplifying customs procedures, and harmonising standards. Technical co-operation programmes have been implemented in areas like agriculture, counter-terrorism, and disaster management. It has also made strides on the cultural front, as was evident with the recent BIMSTEC Aquatic Championship held in February 2024 that India won.

"BIMSTEC is poised to play an important role in enhancing regional co-operation in South Asia and Southeast Asia. Moreover, for the first time at the summit this year, BIMSTEC leaders will adopt a vision document," Pandey tells *BT*.

SAARC VS BIMSTEC

Interest in BIMSTEC has risen as the importance of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (Saarc) has waned. Some members are common to both blocs—India, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Nepal, and Bhutan—but it is the exceptions—Pakistan, Afghanistan, and the Maldives—that indicate the reasons for the shift.

The first big setback in recent years for Saarc was the 2016 terror attack at an Indian army camp in Uri, Kashmir. India pulled out of the planned summit in Pakistan. In fact, the last Saarc summit was held in Kathmandu, Nepal, in 2014.

But there are other reasons for the waning interest, one of which is the requirement of unanimous agreement on major decisions, a requirement that becomes all the more onerous amid tensions between countries.

Agneshwar Sen, Associate Partner, Trade and Indirect-tax Policy Advisory, EY, says, "The political realities of South Asia do not provide any hope for a quick revival in the fortunes of Saarc. Therefore, yes, withering away from Saarc as the primary instrument for greater regional co-operation and development has created the opening for BIMSTEC."

Sen says BIMSTEC also becomes impor-

AIM AND PURPOSE



Support economic growth through collaboration on projects



Work together for economic and social well-being



Collaborate on common economic, social, and scientific goals



Share training and research facilities for education and technical projects



Work together to support national development plans of member states



Build partnerships with similar international and regional organisations

1.8 BILLION

Total population of the member countries, which is 22% of the global population

\$4.5 TRILLION

The combined GDP of the group, which is around 4.45% of global GDP

| 69

SECTOR SPREAD

BIMSTEC's rotational leadership helps promote shared responsibility; each member also leads a sector



Bangladesh Trade, investment, and development



Bhutan Environment and climate change



India Security, energy, and disaster management



Nepal People-to-people contact



Myanmar Agriculture and food security



Sri Lanka Science, technology, and innovation



Thailand Connectivity